

INDIA AND SOUTH AFRICA ARE THE BOOKIES' PICKS TO WIN THE WORLD TWENTY20.



India: 3-1
South Africa: 3-1
Australia: 9-2
Pakistan: 7-1
New Zealand: 8-1
Sri Lanka: 8-1
England: 8-1
West Indies: 12-1
Bangladesh: 40-1
Ireland: 300-1
Scotland: 500-1

Source: William Hill

"People are now playing much better T20 cricket. They realise that even though its only 120 balls there's no need to panic. No matter how bad the start, you don't see scores lower than 125-130 now," he says and adds, "there's a real stress on taking wickets in the first six overs and alternatively, keeping them in hand if you're batting."

Watch out for similar trends in the World T20 because those early wickets have statistically been proved to be fatal. Former India opener Akash Chopra says IPL's data-crunching sessions showed as much: "You can't lose more than two wickets in the first six overs, if you lose say three or four, you waste overs trying to consolidate. Ideally you want to save wickets for the last four overs."

Strategies are worked out on team strengths, so sides with explosive lower order batsmen can afford to have relatively sedate starts and let the big bats explode at the bottom of an innings. It is how the South Africans use Albie Morkel or New Zealand Jacob Oram.

This is precisely what Chopra says, where India have an advantage

over others. All their batsmen from No. 1 to 7 are clean and heavy hitters. "We don't have to depend on any one player to capitalise on the last four overs". India will need strong hearts and legs because their bowlers will have to hold their lines, the spinners their arcs and the fielders their catches when under attack.

The white ball does not swing as much as the red ball in England where Nixon says T20 teaches bowlers focus on a very specific area: specific quadrants of the pitch from where the batsmen can at best find a single—or alternatively attempt a high-risk shot.

TEAMS USE DATA FROM T20 GAMES TO FIND CUES, LIKE LOSING MORE THAN TWO WICKETS IN THE FIRST FOUR OVERS MORE OFTEN LEADS TO DEFEAT.

TWENTY20 CRICKET'S NEWEST POWER TOOL?



Mongoose MMi3



Conventional Bat



It looks like something that wants to be a cricket bat when it grows up. Its makers though call it the "single most radical change to cricket equipment since 1771". The Mongoose MMi3 bat has a blade 33 per cent shorter and the handle 43 per cent longer than the conventional bat. It is intended to be the ultimate long handle, made specially for the all-attack T20 game. The Mongoose, its manufacturers say, generates 20 per cent more power and 15 per cent more batspeed than a regular bat. The rigidity of the blade (which has no splice) and the flexibility of the handle, its makers say, makes the entire bat surface a sweet spot. Approved by the game's lawmakers, the MCC and the ICC, the Mongoose can be used at all levels of the game. Former Aussie batsman Stuart Law tried the mini-bat in a county T20 game towards the end of his innings. The name, says inventor Marcus Codrington-Fernandez, reflects the bat perfectly— "small but ferocious."

Because, of course, in T20, the single is as valuable as a dot ball.

These are many tiny cues around the bigger game that happens at great velocity and requires both a quicksilver mind and a sense of calm. If India are to succeed again, Dhoni and his team must tap into both their outer rock star and their inner Zen.

Writing during the IPL, former India captain Anil Kumble said, "More than in other forms of the game, every catch counts, every mis-field makes a difference to the outcome... You have to be brave and back your instincts, no matter what." England's captain Paul Collingwood said of his team's approach in the World T20: "We have to be brave."

Much has changed in cricket since the heady autumn of 2007. So naturally we're all wondering, could India possibly do it again? Sure. Will they? It depends. On brain, on brawn.

And also on bravery. ■